

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

Start Here - The 1.d4 2.c4 Repertoire

From zero theory to a safe first-game system and a complete course map

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

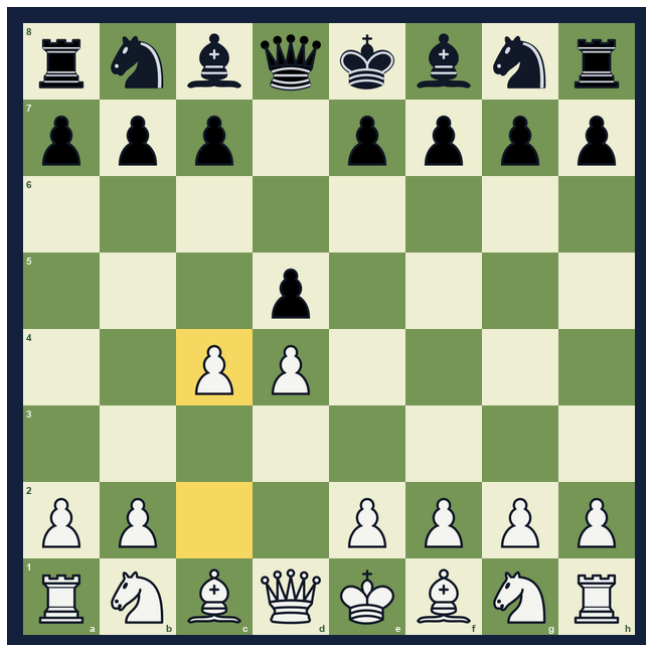
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
FOUNDATIONS	20

01. Why Start With 1.d4



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The d-pawn claims e5, opens the c1-bishop, and usually creates a center that develops more slowly but carries durable space.

PRIMARY PLAN

Claim the center, then decide how c4 will challenge Black's d5-square.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

1.d4 builds a position; it does not demand an immediate attack.

01. Decision Framework

Why Start With 1.d4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

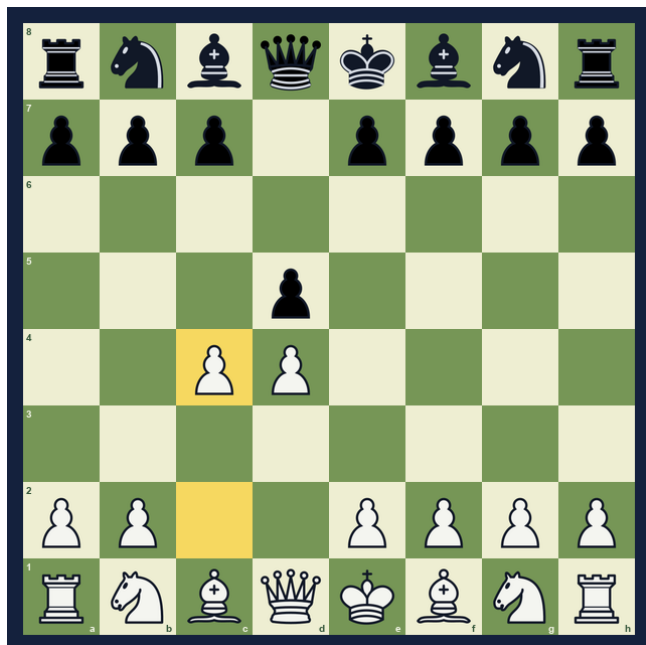
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: 1.d4 builds a position; it does not demand an immediate attack.

02. Why 2.c4 Is the Repertoire Anchor



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The c-pawn attacks d5 without blocking a minor piece and creates the central tension that defines the repertoire.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use c4 to make Black choose between supporting, exchanging, or abandoning the d5-pawn.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

The c-pawn is a lever against d5, not a pawn offered without purpose.

02. Decision Framework

Why 2.c4 Is the Repertoire Anchor

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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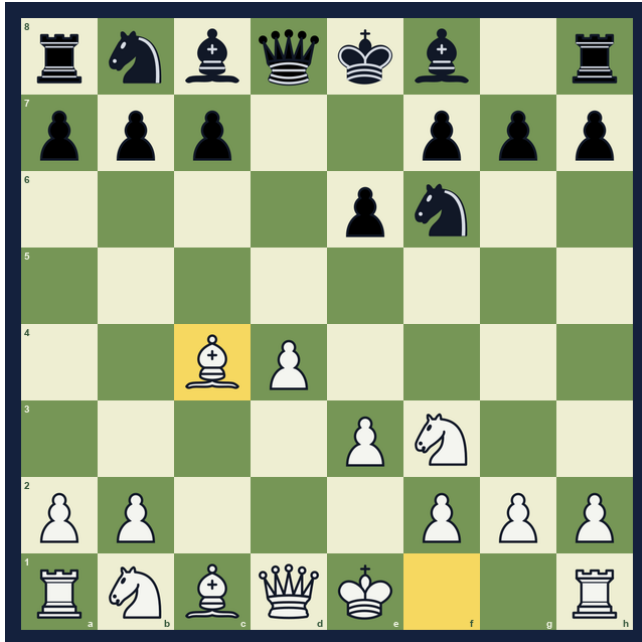
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The c-pawn is a lever against d5, not a pawn offered without purpose.

03. What the Queen's Gambit Actually Gambles



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

After ...dxc4, Black can often keep the pawn only by spending time and weakening the queenside.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop first, then recover c4 with e3, Bxc4, Qa4+, or a4 according to Black's setup.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

White offers time and central influence, not a permanently free pawn.

03. Decision Framework

What the Queen's Gambit Actually Gambles

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
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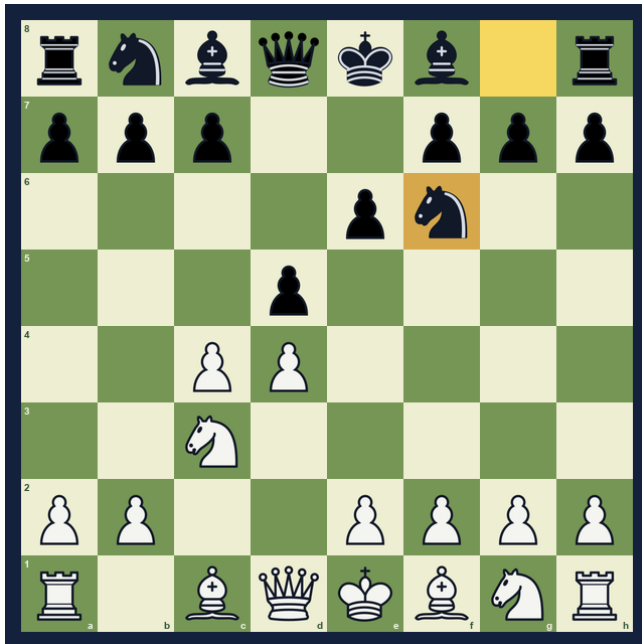
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: White offers time and central influence, not a permanently free pawn.

04. Read the Central Tension



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The pawns on d4, c4, and d5 create options for both sides; resolving the tension changes files, diagonals, and plans.

PRIMARY PLAN

Keep the tension while it restricts Black; exchange only when the resulting structure helps a concrete plan.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Do not capture because you can; capture because the new structure improves your pieces.

04. Decision Framework

Read the Central Tension

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Do not capture because you can; capture because the new structure improves your pieces.

05. The Basic White Development Map



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

Nf3, Nc3, e3, Bd3 or Be2, O-O, and a useful queen placement form the normal skeleton.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop toward the center while leaving the c1-bishop a route outside or through the pawn chain.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

Every developing move should support the center or prepare a break.

05. Decision Framework

The Basic White Development Map

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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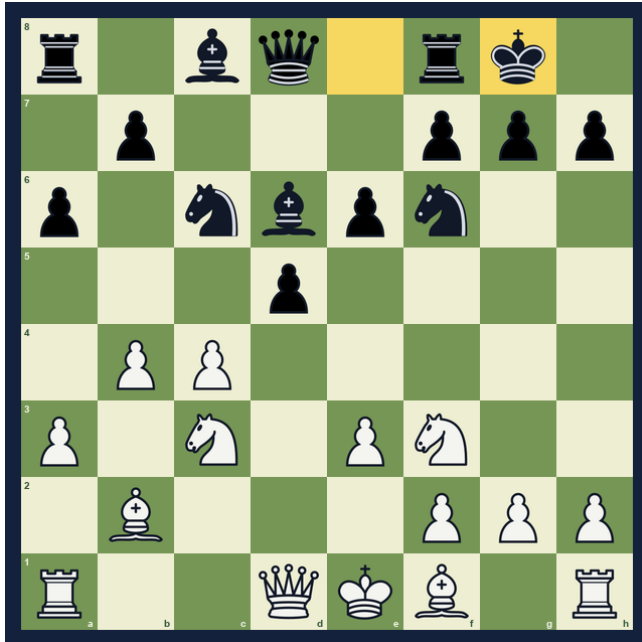
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Every developing move should support the center or prepare a break.

06. The Job of the d-Pawn



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The d4-pawn controls c5 and e5, gains space, and often becomes the base of White's center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Support it when Black attacks; advance or exchange it only when the resulting lines favor White.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

The d-pawn is strong while it controls squares and gives pieces useful space.

06. Decision Framework

The Job of the d-Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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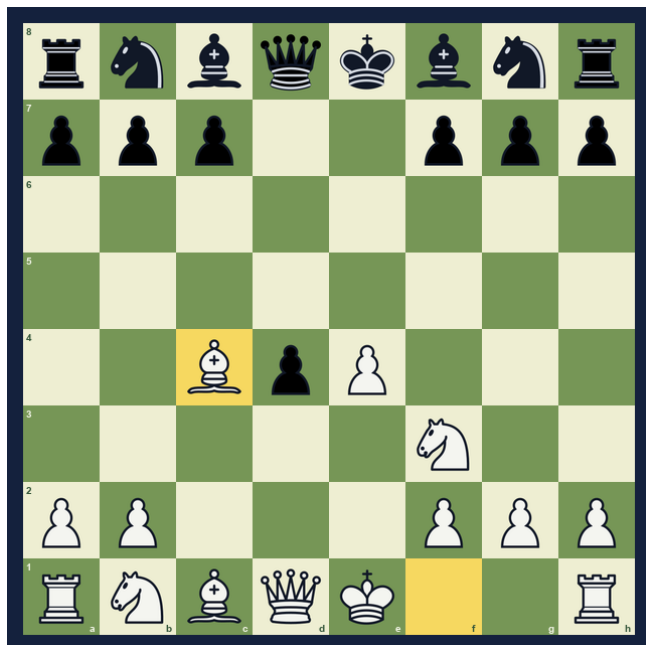
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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The d-pawn is strong while it controls squares and gives pieces useful space.

07. The Job of the c-Pawn



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The c-pawn creates tension, opens the c-file after exchanges, and can become a queenside majority lever.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use cxd5, c5, or recapture cxd5 only after picturing the new structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

The c-pawn's value is the transformation it creates.

07. Decision Framework

The Job of the c-Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The c-pawn's value is the transformation it creates.

08. White's e4 Dream



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

A supported e4-pawn gives White a broad center and more space, but Black will attack it with pieces and pawn breaks.

PRIMARY PLAN

Prepare e4 with development and calculate ...dxe4, ...c5, or ...e5 before committing.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Build e4 when it is a supported center, not a hopeful pawn push.

08. Decision Framework

White's e4 Dream

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Build e4 when it is a supported center, not a hopeful pawn push.

09. Where the Knights Usually Belong



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

Nf3 supports d4 and e5; Nc3 increases pressure on d5 but can permit a Nimzo-Indian pin.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Nf3 early when you want a stable move order; play Nc3 when its central pressure is worth Black's pinning options.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Knight placement chooses which opening families Black can enter.

09. Decision Framework

Where the Knights Usually Belong

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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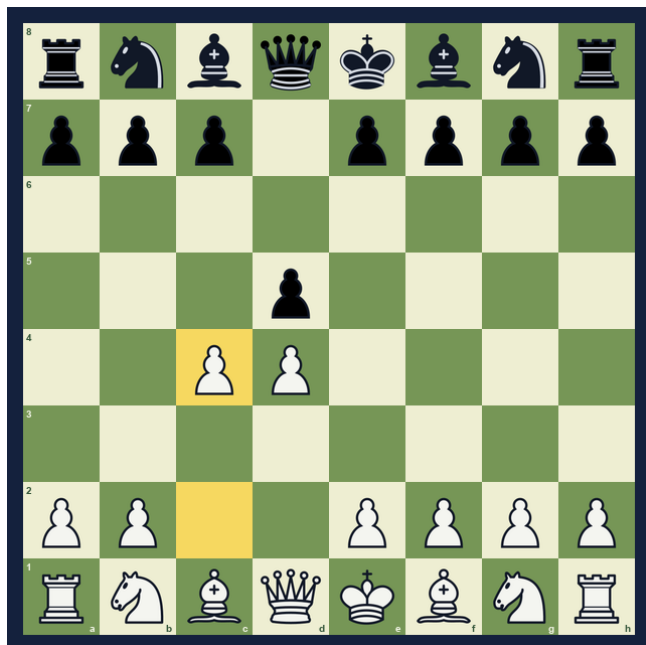
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Knight placement chooses which opening families Black can enter.

10. Solve the c1-Bishop



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The queen's bishop is often White's hardest piece because e3 can close its diagonal.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop it to f4 or g5 when safe, fianchetto it with g3, or prepare b3 and Bb2 after the center is stable.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

A repertoire is healthy when the c1-bishop has a planned job.

10. Decision Framework

Solve the c1-Bishop

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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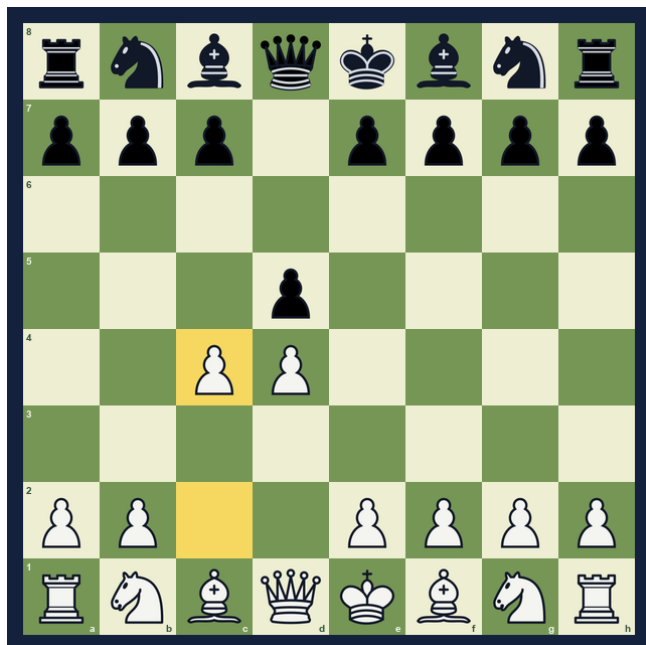
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A repertoire is healthy when the c1-bishop has a planned job.

11. The Light-Squared Bishop's Jobs



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The f1-bishop may pressure c4, h7, or the queenside and often supports rapid castling.

PRIMARY PLAN

Choose Bd3 for kingside influence, Be2 for stability, g2 for a long diagonal, or c4 to recover the gambit pawn.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

The bishop's square follows the pawn structure, not habit.

11. Decision Framework

The Light-Squared Bishop's Jobs

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
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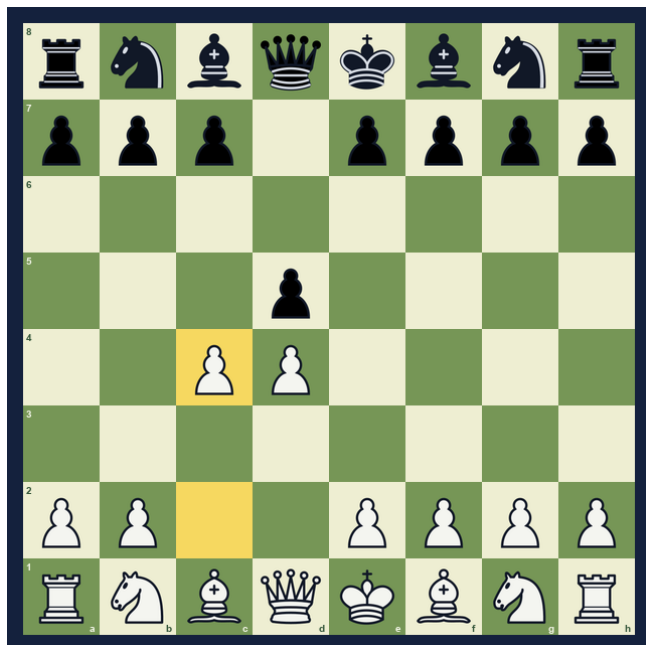
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The bishop's square follows the pawn structure, not habit.

12. Queen Placement Without Early Exposure



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The queen often supports c4 recovery, e4, or a queenside break but can lose time when developed too early.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use Qc2, Qa4+, Qb3, or Qd2 only when the move solves a specific opening problem.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

A queen move should create pressure or complete a plan, not merely look active.

12. Decision Framework

Queen Placement Without Early Exposure

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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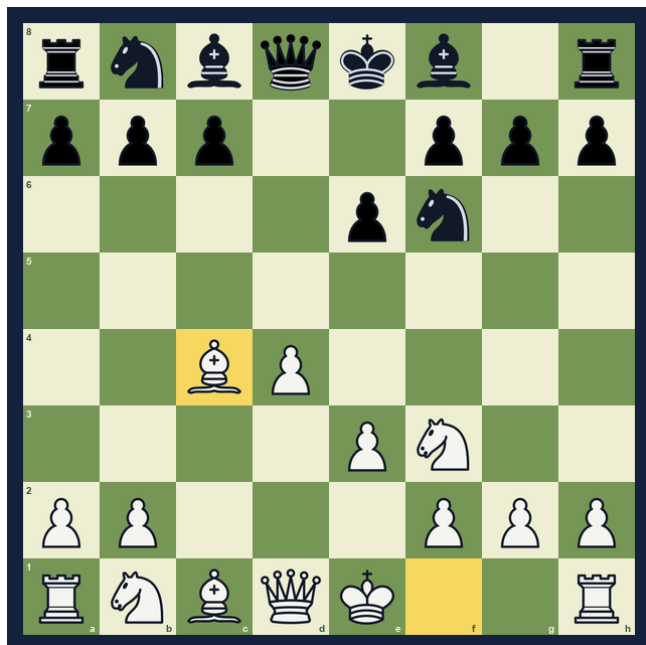
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NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A queen move should create pressure or complete a plan, not merely look active.

13. Rooks Need a File and an Entry Square



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

After central exchanges, the c-, d-, and e-files become the main highways.

PRIMARY PLAN

Place a rook behind the break or on the file whose entry square can actually be used.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Name the entry square before claiming an open file.

13. Decision Framework

Rooks Need a File and an Entry Square

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Name the entry square before claiming an open file.

14. When to Play cxd5



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

Capturing on d5 can create a Carlsbad structure, an isolated pawn, or open central files.

PRIMARY PLAN

Decide whether the exchange improves White's minority attack, e4 break, or piece activity.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

cxd5 is a structural decision, not an automatic release of tension.

14. Decision Framework

When to Play cxd5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: cxd5 is a structural decision, not an automatic release of tension.

15. When Black Plays ...dxc4



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

Black releases the center and asks White to recover c4 without wasting time.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop with Nf3 and e3, then recover the pawn while preventing ...b5 consolidation.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE 1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

Recover c4 through development; do not send the queen pawn-hunting.

15. Decision Framework

When Black Plays ...dxc4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

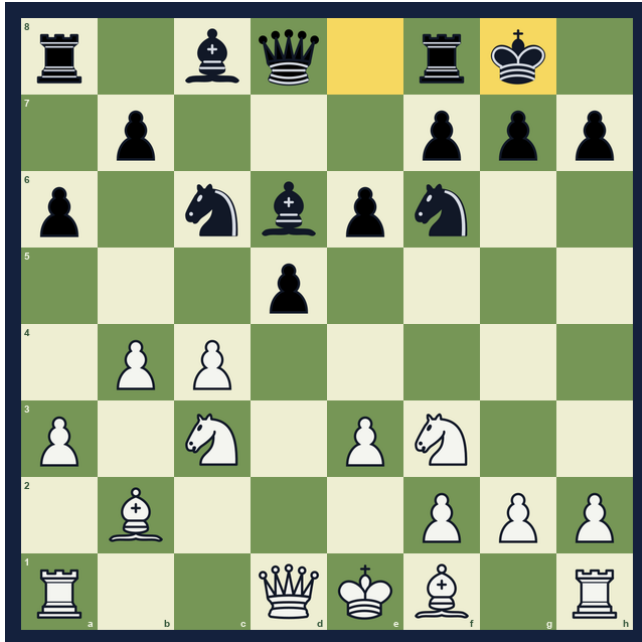
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Recover c4 through development; do not send the queen pawn-hunting.

16. Move Orders and Transpositions



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

The same structure can arise through 1...d5, 1...Nf6, 1...e6, or delayed central moves.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify the pawn structure and available breaks instead of relying on the opening's name.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

The board position outranks the label.

16. Decision Framework

Move Orders and Transpositions

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
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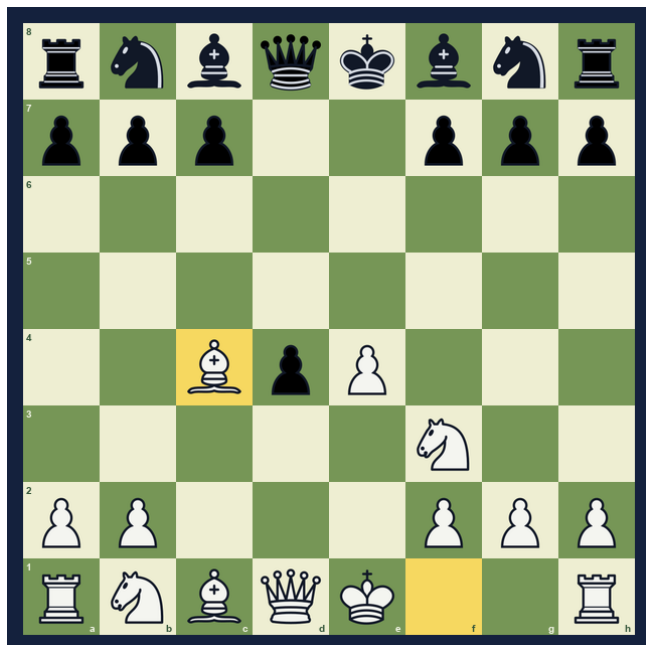
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The board position outranks the label.

17. The First Safety Scan



REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Theory begins only after the position is tactically safe.

FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

Even familiar theory can hide a check, capture, pin, or loose piece after one unusual move.

PRIMARY PLAN

Before recalling theory, check Black's last move, threats, forcing replies, and changes to the center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

17. Decision Framework

The First Safety Scan

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Theory begins only after the position is tactically safe.

18. Learn Landmarks Instead of Telephone Numbers



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

A tabiya is a meaningful position with known plans, breaks, and piece jobs.

PRIMARY PLAN

Store the landmark, the route into it, and the first move that changes the plan.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Remember positions plus reasons, not unconnected move strings.

18. Decision Framework

Learn Landmarks Instead of Telephone Numbers

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Remember positions plus reasons, not unconnected move strings.

19. Your Emergency Repertoire



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

A simple setup is useful while deeper theory is still being learned.

PRIMARY PLAN

Against ...d5 use Nf3, Nc3, e3, Bd3, and O-O; against ...Nf6 identify ...e6, ...g6, or ...c5 before choosing the setup.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e6 3. Nf3 d5 4. Nc3

MEMORY RULE

Develop, secure the king, preserve the center, and refuse unsound pawn grabs.

19. Decision Framework

Your Emergency Repertoire

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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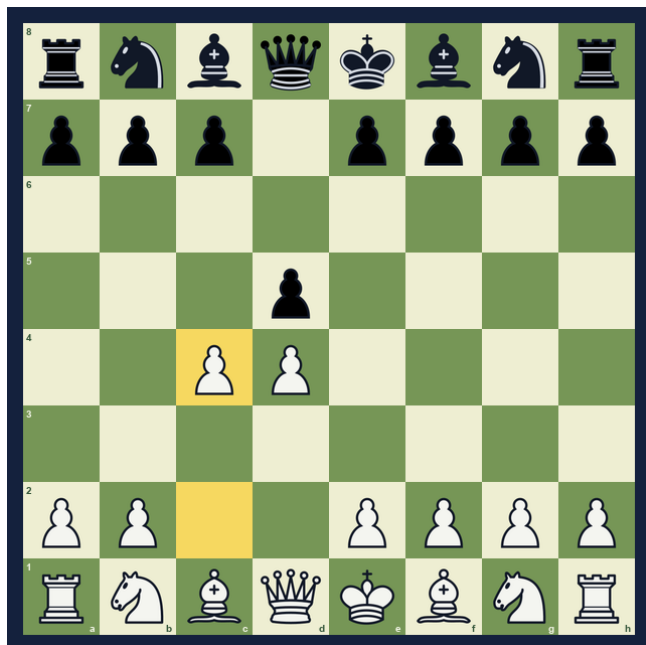
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Develop, secure the king, preserve the center, and refuse unsound pawn grabs.

20. How to Study This Course



FOUNDATIONS

READ THE POSITION

Opening knowledge becomes usable through reconstruction, prediction, and review after real games.

PRIMARY PLAN

Study one chapter, close the book, rebuild the position, complete its workbook page, and review after one day and one week.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

Retrieval changes play; rereading mainly changes familiarity.

20. Decision Framework

How to Study This Course

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Retrieval changes play; rereading mainly changes familiarity.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.